I was born when my father, a well-to-do businessman who traded in copra, coir and oil in Trivandrum, suddenly realised that he either miscalculated his life or never bothered to calculate at all. He had partnered with his elder brother, and together they had made quite a fortune when his brother died. Suddenly, the brother's wife, my aunt, said my father had no right over the capital, savings or profit. He fought a case for eleven years.

It was at the end of my father's eleven-year legal battle that I was born on 12 December 1941. The first boy in the family after four girls, my arrival was considered a lucky omen as within a month the court settled the business dispute in my father's favour. He got his fair share of the business, but was still in no mood to rejoice as he felt sad about having got into a duel with the family of his brother who he so adored.

Adding to father's misery, his brother's wife committed suicide, probably because she could not take the outcome of the long drawn court case. My father could well have continued his business in Trivandrum, but so heartbroken he was that he decided to pack his things and move the family to Nagercoil, where he would start an oil business, with modest results. I was a few months old then.

I have no memories of my father struggling; he kept us happy. We lived in a decent house that had electricity and water supply, which were not common in the early 1940s in that southern tip of India. As for school uniforms, books and other facilities, I did not have to ask. And I loved mathematics.

But my initiation to schooling was not easy—at least for my mom. When admitted to the first standard at the Parakkamadai Government School in Nagercoil, I just refused to go. The reason was simple: I wanted to be with my mother. When she offered to come along to the school, she did not know what she was getting into.

I agreed to go to school under the condition that mother stood outside my class, in my field of vision. She must have thought she could slip away back home after a couple of days of this torture, but every time she disappeared from my sight, I would make a hell out of it forcing the teacher to stop the class and bring back my mother to stand outside the classroom.